Working in Factory Automation: A 10–20 Year Strategy Career View

Layoffs, culture, compensation by region, future pay capacity and an employer recommendation for a senior corporate-strategy professional

Report 3 of 3 · Prepared 28 October 2026

$260–400k
US director-level strategy total comp at FA majors [EST]

2–3×
Big tech / PE pay at the same seniority

4.0–4.2
Glassdoor: Schneider, Siemens, Honeywell, ABB (Rockwell 3.7)

~50%
Chance of a company-wide cut at your employer by 2029 [EST]

Recommendation

Stay in factory automation, and aim for Siemens or Schneider Electric; ABB is the best-paid alternative. The industry is growing ~6–7% a year and is in its busiest portfolio-reshaping period ever, so senior strategy, M&A and integration skills are central rather than overhead. **Siemens** offers the largest, most durable strategy organisation, the strongest franchise and German employment protection. **Schneider** is the most strategy-intensive employer for the next five years (the $23.7B PTC integration, divestments, software pivot) with the best employee sentiment and a multi-hub HQ (Paris, Boston, Hong Kong, Bangalore). **ABB** in Zurich pays the most on a risk-adjusted basis but has a thin central HQ. Avoid HQ strategy roles at Japanese firms unless you are fluent in Japanese, and treat Honeywell and Emerson as deal-experience employers rather than 20-year homes. Your biggest pay lever is the step from Director to VP or business-unit GM, not the choice of company.

Employer ranking for a senior strategy professional (10–20 year view) [EST]

#	Employer	Why	Main concern
1	**Siemens** (Munich; US software in Plano)	Largest, durable strategy function; deepest internal mobility (DI, SI, Mobility, Advanta); global #1 franchise; no forced redundancies in Germany; Director of Strategy postings $169–328k base in the US	Bureaucracy, slow promotion; DI cut 5,600 jobs in 2025; Healthineers spin
2	**Schneider Electric** (Paris, Boston, HK, Bangalore)	Most strategy-intensive (PTC, India buyout, €1–1.5B divestments, software ~25% of revenue by 2030); best Glassdoor (4.2, 87% recommend); data-center tailwind	CEO turnover (2024); PTC overlap cuts 2027–28; heavy matrix
3	**ABB** (Zurich)	Best risk-adjusted pay (Swiss TDC ~$350–520k, low tax); record margins, net cash; strong process + electrification	Thin central HQ ('ABB Way'): few senior central seats
4	**Emerson** (St. Louis)	Highest margins; AspenTech/NI software; clear 2028 plan	Lean post-integration center; tenure-based RIFs reported
5	**Rockwell** (Milwaukee)	Pure-play automation; focused strategy agenda (software, partnerships)	Most cyclical; HQ/SG&A cut in 2024; lowest sentiment (3.7, 70% CEO approval)
6	**Honeywell Technologies** (Charlotte)	Unmatched separation/M&A experience; new standalone strategy function	Least stable seat; activist on board; rolling repositioning
—	Japanese majors / Inovance	Stable (Keyence, Fanuc) or growing (Inovance)	HQ strategy closed to non-Japanese/Mandarin speakers; use US/EU subsidiaries (Omron Americas best)

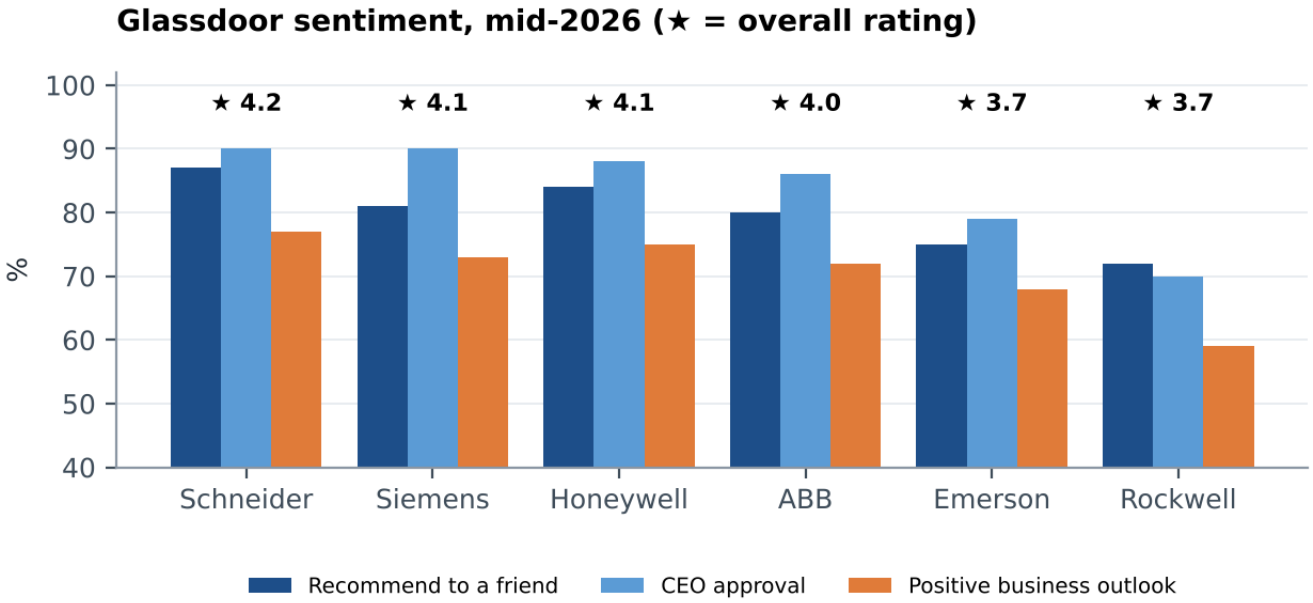
1. Layoff and restructuring history

The 2023–25 downturn produced cuts at most leaders, and they fell disproportionately on SG&A and headquarters functions. The newer, bigger risk for an HQ strategist is portfolio change: spins and sales first create strategy work, then shrink corporate centers 12–24 months later.

Company	2019–2023	2024–2026	Who was hit
Siemens	Energy spin (2020)	**Mar 2025: ~5,600 DI jobs** (~2,600 Germany) by Sep 2027; 450 eMobility	Automation capacity; no forced redundancies in Germany
Schneider	AVEVA integration cuts	CEO removed Nov 2024; French plant consolidation (~145 jobs); €500M restructuring 2025–27	Factories, not HQ; PTC overlap ahead
ABB	'ABB Way' removed group HQ layer (2019–20)	Robotics (~7,000 staff) sold to SoftBank; 3-BA reorganisation	Business-area staff
Rockwell	—	**May 2024: ~870 (3%)**; headcount 29k → 26k by 2025	**Sales, marketing, HQ Milwaukee**; acquired AMR unit
Emerson	**2020: ~2,900 salaried**	NI and AspenTech integration; Charlottesville site closing (139)	Acquired/overlapping units; tenure-based selection reported
Honeywell	Annual repositioning charges	Three-way split (2025–26); PSS, Intelligrated, PPE sold	Corporate functions duplicated, then rationalised
Mitsubishi Electric	—	Early retirement for 53+: **~4,700** (despite record profit)	Older white-collar staff
Omron	—	**2024: ~2,000** (1,000 Japan, 1,000 overseas)	Broad; second big cut in 90 years
Keyence, Fanuc, Yaskawa	None found	None found (Yaskawa: Europe restructuring)	—

Sources: Reuters via TrendForce, Control Global, company IR, Virginia WARN, Eurofound. TeamBlind and TheLayoff threads were not retrieved.

2. Employee feedback and culture



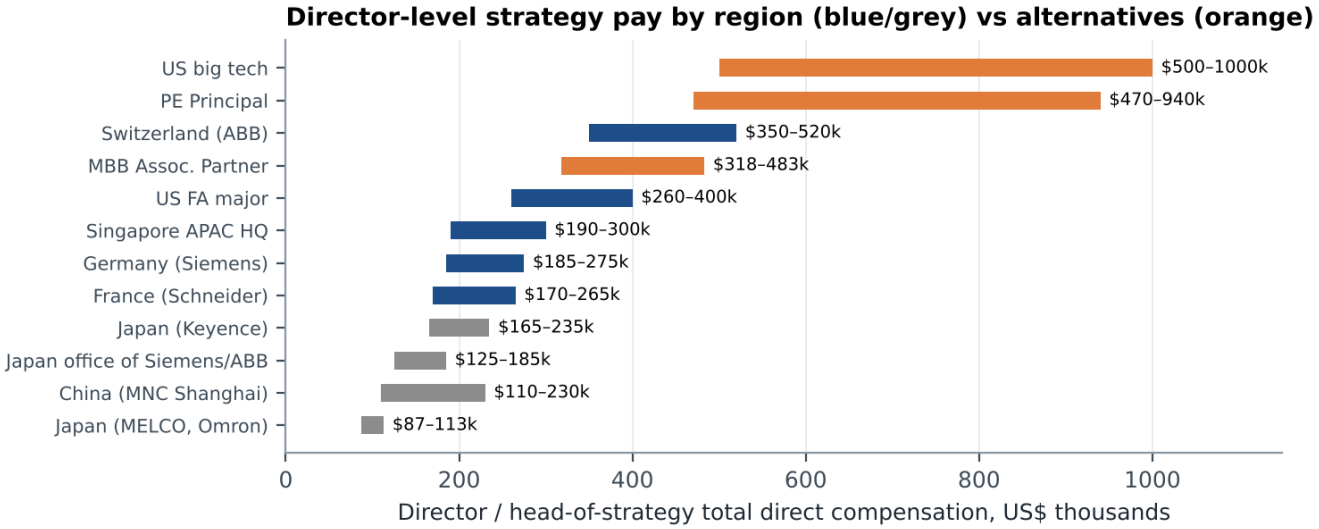
Glassdoor pages fetched Oct 2026. Japanese firms and Inovance not covered on Glassdoor; Keyence from one OpenWork review (~¥15M pay, ~60 h/month overtime).

Company	What employees like	What they complain about	Note for a strategist
Schneider	Pay/benefits, hybrid work, culture, sustainability story	Credential-driven progression, matrix	Global hubs; HQ cuts rare (EU labor law)
Siemens	CEO, benefits, job security (Germany)	Bureaucracy, slow decisions, middle-management politics	Huge internal mobility, slow promotion
ABB	Culture, pace, fair pay	Chaotic; many stakeholders	Strategy sits mostly in business areas
Honeywell	Brand, performance focus	Short-termism, cut-throat culture, turnover	Metrics-heavy; 3 days/week in office
Emerson	Supportive managers, work-life balance	Powerful HR, tenure-based RIFs, complacency	Busy during deals, lean afterwards
Rockwell	People, collegial Milwaukee culture	Layoff anxiety, limited opportunities	Lowest outlook (59%)
Japanese firms	Stability (Keyence: very high pay)	Seniority, Japanese-only decisions, 53+ early retirement	HQ planning goes to long-tenured insiders

- **Work arrangements:** Honeywell requires 3 office days a week; Rockwell runs a hybrid programme but stresses face-to-face; Siemens' 2–3 mobile days a week is long-standing [not re-verified]; Japanese firms are office-centric.
- **Mobility:** Siemens, Schneider and ABB have the deepest global-rotation and expatriate programmes — useful for a global strategy career.
- **Mood 2025–26:** improving with the upcycle, but companies are expanding margins through 'flat headcount, rising margin' rather than rehiring.

3. Compensation: by region and against other careers

Factory-automation majors pay a 15-year strategy professional well by any normal standard — a US director sits near the BLS chief-executive median ($269.6k mean) — but at the low-to-mid end of what the same profile earns in big tech, PE or senior consulting. The gap is almost entirely equity.



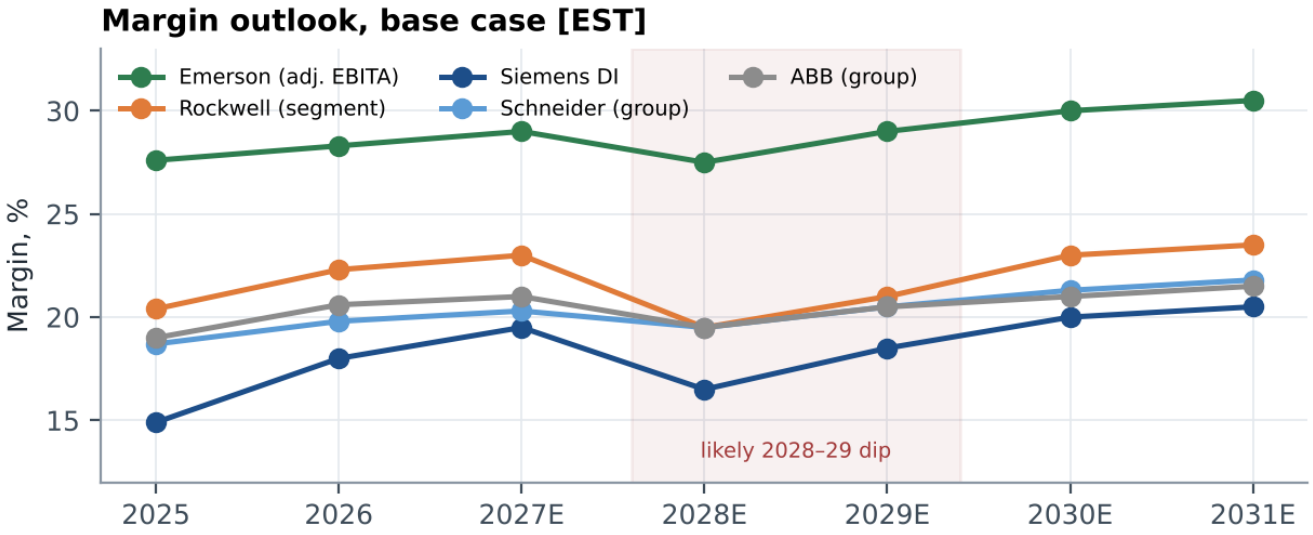
Synthesis of Siemens US pay-transparency postings, H-1B title data, Glassdoor, Levels.fyi, Michael Page 2026, JAC Recruitment, Heidrick PE survey and Japanese securities filings. Most non-US figures are estimates [EST], ±20%.

US ladder at FA majors [EST]	Base	Bonus target	LTI (annual)	Total at target
Senior Manager, Strategy / Corp Dev	$160–200k	15–20%	0–15% of base	$185–250k
Director, Strategy / Corp Dev	**$190–260k**	**25–30%**	**20–50% of base**	**$260–400k**
Senior Director / Head of Strategy (BU)	$240–310k	30–40%	50–100%	$400–600k
VP Strategy / Corp Dev (enterprise)	$300–425k	50–60%	100–200%	$600k–1.2M

- **Evidence:** Siemens US Director of Strategy postings $191–328k base + 25% bonus and $168.7–303.7k; Siemens M&A Strategist $147.5–206.6k + 10–15%; H-1B 'Director, Corporate Strategy' median $214k base (2024, all employers); Glassdoor US Director of Strategy median ~$247k total.
- **Japan:** corporate-planning department head ~¥11.8M (~$79k), division head ~¥15.4M; Keyence average ¥20.4M at age 35 — but almost no strategy roles. Japanese firms grant essentially no equity below officer level.
- **Equity tailwind:** ABB, Schneider and Siemens hit record share prices in 2026 on data-center electrification, so 2023–24 grants vest 10–25% above target. Schneider has since fallen ~20% from its September high — new grants carry more risk.
- **Promotion economics:** Director → VP or BU general manager roughly doubles total pay through LTI. Staying in staff strategy usually tops out at Senior Director.

4. Projection: margins, opex and willingness to pay

Using Report 1's industry scenarios and Report 2's company assumptions, the leading Western employers should keep expanding margins through 2031. But their plans deliver that expansion mainly through **cost discipline** — flat headcount, SG&A productivity and restructuring — not through higher pay. Capacity to pay is high; appetite is moderate.



2025 actual; 2026 = latest run-rate/guidance; 2027–31 analyst estimates anchored on company targets (Emerson 30% by 2028; Schneider +250bp by 2030; ABB 18–22%; Siemens DI back to ~20%).

[EST]	2026	2028 (base, dip year)	2031 (base)	Bear 2028-29
Industry revenue (Report 1)	~$230B	~$245B	~$315B	~$212–218B
Leader margins	18–28%	16–27%	20–30%	12–22%
SG&A / opex growth	+3–5%	Flat to −3% (cost programmes)	+3–4%/yr	−5 to −8%
Merit raises	3–5%	2–3%	3–4%	Freeze
Bonus payout vs target	100–130%	60–90%	~100%	0–50%
LTI realised vs grant	+10–25% (record shares)	Below target	~Target	Well below
Company-wide cut (≥3% staff) at a given major	Low (<15%)	Medium (35–45%)	Low-medium	High (70–80%)

Will a senior strategy role be safe from layoffs?

Horizon	What drives the risk	Risk for a senior HQ strategist [EST]
2026–2027	Upcycle; deal execution (PTC, Robotics sale, Rotork, Healthineers spin)	Low; demand for strategy/M&A/integration is high
2027–2029	Post-deal center slimming (Schneider–PTC, Honeywell post-split, Emerson integrations) + likely cyclical dip	Medium (15–25%); highest at Honeywell, Emerson, Rockwell
2030–2035	Software/AI transition, possible China export pressure, further portfolio moves	Medium; skills in software economics and M&A protect best
Japan HQ roles	53+ early-retirement programmes even in record years	High for older staff; low access for outsiders
Germany / France HQ roles	Co-determination, no forced redundancies, attrition-based cuts	Lowest structural risk

Your protection is not the employer's balance sheet (all are strong) but your position on the deal and software agenda: strategists who lead integrations, separations, partnerships and software monetisation are the last to be cut.

5. A 10–20 year plan

Period	Industry state	What to do
2026–2028	Upcycle; record deal activity; software and AI pivot	Join Siemens or Schneider in a strategy/M&A role tied to a live transformation (Schneider–PTC integration, Siemens software/AI, ABB portfolio). Negotiate LTI in currency terms; ask for a sign-on to replace forfeited equity.
2028–2030	Probable cyclical dip; post-deal corporate-center slimming	Be on the critical path (integration PMO, carve-outs, ARR strategy, Nvidia/Microsoft alliances). Push for a VP or BU-GM step — the largest pay jump available.
2030–2035	~$300B+ market, software ~30%+ of profit; China export pressure	Move from staff strategy into P&L or enterprise VP strategy; or use the domain + deal record to exit to PE (industrial-tech operating roles) or software corp dev.
2035–2046	Physical AI and software-defined control mature	Senior leadership (CSO, BU head) or board/PE roles. Factory-automation domain knowledge stays valuable because the industry keeps growing.

Choosing between Siemens and Schneider

- **Choose Siemens** for scale, stability and breadth: the largest strategy community, many internal moves (DI, Smart Infrastructure, Mobility, Advanta consulting), the clearest factory-automation franchise, and German employment protection if based in Munich. Accept slower promotion and bureaucracy.
- **Choose Schneider** for the most strategy-intensive 5 years — PTC is a once-in-a-decade integration — plus the best culture scores and a genuinely multi-hub organisation that suits a global career. Accept higher leadership volatility and possible overlap cuts in 2027–28.
- **By region:** US for the highest cash (US majors and US units of European firms); Zurich (ABB) for best risk-adjusted pay; Singapore for an APAC strategy-head role; Japan only via a foreign firm's Japan office or Omron's US/EU hubs.
- **Exit options ranked by growth:** data-center power and cooling (Vertiv, Eaton), robotics/physical-AI start-ups, industrial-software acquirers, PE portfolio roles; consulting is the weakest market now.

Final answer: Yes — factory automation is a good long-term home for a senior strategy professional: growing, profitable and in the middle of a structural reshaping that puts strategy at the center. Aim for **Siemens** (stability and breadth) or **Schneider Electric** (most strategy work, best culture), with **ABB** as the best-paid alternative. Expect at least one restructuring cycle before 2030, protect yourself by owning deal and software work, and plan your pay growth around a VP or business-unit leadership step rather than around the employer.

[EST] = analyst estimate. Ratings and pay are self-reported, posted or from filings as labelled. Not financial or career advice.

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